Securitising the Ballot: Computational Modelling of Securitising Rhetoric in UK Party Manifestos

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Abstract—Since 9/11, national security has become central to political discourse across Western democracies, mirrored in the UK by successive security legislation criticised for impacting civil liberties. Tracing this discourse across parties over time could reveal patterns qualitative analysis cannot scale to, but existing computational approaches lack the theoretical grounding and analytical breadth needed. This work investigates convergence in securitising rhetoric among UK parties post-9/11 and examines how shifts in party-level rhetoric relate temporally to public opinion salience and legislation criticised for restricting civil liberties. I use a multi-head transformer-based intensity regression model trained on hand-labelled manifesto sentences to predict sentence-level securitisation intensity across three theoretically-grounded dimensions of threat, urgency and justification. Theory-derived lexicons label the unlabelled corpus to provide auxiliary supervision. The resulting time series is analysed against public opinion and legislative records. The selected model achieved macro Spearman 0.524 and macro QWK 0.623 on the held-out set and 5-fold cross-validation confirmed generalisation (macro Spearman 0.487 ± 0.016). I found that UK securitising rhetoric diverged, with threat becoming a shared baseline across the largest parties whilst urgency distinguished the governing party, and that the governing party legislated most when its securitising rhetoric was weakest.

Index Terms—Discourse, Machine learning, Natural Language Processing, Social and Behavioral Sciences

1 Introduction

Since the 9/11 terror attacks, national security has taken on a central position in political discourse across Western democracies, reshaping the boundaries between state authority and civil liberties in ways that prompted sustained political and academic debate [1]. The UK visibly demonstrates this trajectory, where this discourse has been accompanied by successive legislation spanning counter-terrorism, surveillance, immigration and digital regulation that all progressively expand the state's enforcement and monitoring capacities [2], [3]. Laws like the Counter-Terrorism and Security Act (2015), the Investigatory Powers Act (2016) and the Online Safety Act (2023) trace a pattern in which security imperatives are increasingly prioritised at the expense of individual freedoms, raising pressing questions about where the appropriate limits of governmental power lie [4], [5].

Securitisation theory, developed by the Copenhagen School of security studies [6], offers a robust framework for examining this pattern. Instead of treating security as an objective condition, it conceptualises it as a political construct produced through discourse, in which actors frame issues as existential threats to a valued referent object (typically a state or society) and assert urgency through time-compressive language to legitimise exceptional measures that bypass ordinary democratic governance. Within this framework the effectiveness of these moves is less dependent on the objective severity of the threat and more on whether the narrative is sufficiently articulated to secure audience acceptance, which makes the construction of rhetoric the primary variable to analyse. In the UK, political parties have used this type of language when discussing domains from terrorism and immigration to cyberattacks and online harm, making them central securitising actors whose discourse warrants systematic scrutiny [7], [8].

Party manifestos provide a particularly valuable medium to trace securitising discourse. Unlike political speeches, which inherently react to immediate events and are designed to provoke, manifestos articulate longer-term political priorities in a more measured and deliberate format, consequently offering insight into how security issues are framed within formal policy, often before they translate to legislation [9]. Shifts in securitising language within manifestos may consequently reflect and reinforce broader transformations in how security and civil liberties are negotiated within democratic governance, and where these shifts precede legislation, tracing them could provide an early signal that legislative changes with civil-liberty implications are approaching ahead of enactment.

However, securitisation discourse analysis at scale is methodologically challenging. Rarely can securitising language be accurately captured through keywords alone; instead, it consists of nuanced combinations of threat framing, urgent, time-compressive wording and justification of extraordinary measures, embedded within complex political language [10]. Traditional qualitative approaches cannot scale across the longitudinal, multi-party corpora that

temporal analysis requires [11], but Natural Language Processing (NLP) offers a more feasible alternative, with prior work demonstrating that supervised and transformer-based approaches applied to manifesto corpora can reliably track party ideology and rhetorical emphasis across electoral cycles [12], [13]. However, existing computational approaches to political discourse tend to model single-output measures like topic distributions, ideological constructs or sentiment proxies [14], [15], [16] which rarely are designed to capture the multi-dimensional and performative structures in discourse that securitisation analysis requires, as Section 2 examines in detail.

1.1 Research Questions

Motivated by this gap, this study investigates the primary research question: "To what extent do UK political party manifestos post-9/11 exhibit rhetorical convergence in securitising language across parties and electoral cycles?" Here I define rhetorical convergence as a narrowing of cross-party differences in either the volume or the intensity of securitising language over time. Establishing how this discourse evolves is the basis for my second question: "How do shifts in party-level securitising rhetoric relate temporally to public opinion salience on security-relevant issues and to a curated set of securitising legislation criticised as restrictive of civil liberties?" Together, these questions seek to determine whether changes in elite political framing precede, accompany or follow broader shifts in legislative practice and public engagement, thus contributing to an understanding of how securitising rhetoric may operate as a precursor to governance change instead of just a reflection of it.

1.2 Project Objectives

To investigate these questions, the project presents a theory-guided NLP framework for detecting and quantifying securitising signals within UK party manifestos. Drawing directly from securitisation theory, I operationalise three theoretically distinct linguistic dimensions: threat framing, urgency articulation and justification of extraordinary power. I train a multi-head intensity regression model based on DeBERTa-v3-base to estimate sentence-level intensities across these dimensions, learning how linguistic features correspond to varying degrees of securitising rhetoric from a hand-labelled subset of the manifesto corpus. Due to the limited scale of manual annotation, I extend the training signal using theory-derived lexicons (one per securitisation dimension) whose terms are manually graded into core, secondary and contextual tiers of decreasing rhetorical intensity. These lexicons generate weighted pseudo-labels for unlabelled sentences, introducing structured and intensity-sensitive domain knowledge as an auxiliary training signal. I evaluate this approach through a controlled design consisting of a gold-only baseline and two auxiliary variants that additionally incorporate lexicon-derived signals across different dimension subsets, keeping all other architectural and training configurations constant.

The model's continuous, dimension-level predictions are then aggregated into a cross-party longitudinal time series of securitisation intensity to enable examination of how securitising rhetoric shifts across electoral cycles and whether there is any evidence of rhetorical convergence between parties. These time series then provide the basis for my exploratory temporal analysis into whether observed shifts in securitising discourse precede, follow or co-evolve with broader contextual developments, namely legislative changes and fluctuations in public opinion salience.

1.3 Contribution

The project contributes three outputs beyond addressing the aforementioned research questions directly. The core methodological contribution is a theory-guided, multi-head regression framework that operationalises securitisation as a continuous and multi-dimensional process, providing a tool that is more grounded in the core theoretical constructs of securitisation theory than existing approaches offer. By producing structured, dimension-level intensity scores beyond the typical binary classifications and topic distributions currently available, this framework may support researchers and policy analysts in tracking securitising rhetoric across parties and electoral cycles, with moments of notable intensification serving as potential indicators of rhetorical escalation warranting closer analytical scrutiny.

Additionally it contributes an original annotated dataset of 1,500 manifesto sentences drawn from UK party manifestos and labelled on a 0-3 ordinal scale across each of the three securitisation dimensions, alongside a further 250 pre-period sentences annotated for training augmentation. I created the annotation set using proportionate sampling to mitigate biases due to variation in manifesto count and length across parties. The codebook I used is provided in Appendix A for transparency and reproducibility. Given the scarcity of labelled resources for studying securitising rhetoric in political text, this dataset provides a structured foundation for future NLP-driven political communication research. Alongside it, the tiered lexicons developed for weak supervision provide a reusable methodological asset adaptable to securitisation analysis in other political corpora.

Section 2 critically evaluates computational approaches to political text analysis and identifies the methodological gaps motivating the framework I propose here, Section 3 details this framework's design and experimental methodology and Sections 4 and 5 report results and evaluation.

2 Related Work

2.1 Computational Analysis of Political Discourse

The computational analysis of political discourse emerged from the "text-as-data" paradigm, which reframed political language as a quantifiable data source that can be systematically analysed on a large-scale [17]. Early approaches within this paradigm mainly used lexical frequency-based methods, with the most prominent being Wordscore, which allows policy positions to be estimated by comparing word distributions across reference and target corpora to facilitate cross-party comparison without manual coding [18], [19]. Whilst these approaches scale effectively, they are confined to surface-level distributional patterns ill-suited to capturing rhetorical intensity, interpretive nuance or the multi-dimensional structure of securitising discourse [17], [20].

To address those limitations, research increasingly adopted probabilistic and structure-aware methods, including topic models like Latent Dirichlet Allocation and the Structural Topic Model used to identify latent thematic structures without predefined categories [16], [21], and supervised classification methods applied to ideological placement in legislative text [22], [23]. However, both families of methods are constrained to representing thematic content instead of rhetorical construction and intensity, which makes them insufficient proxies for the framing and discursive structure central to securitisation [24], [25]. Fully-supervised approaches are further constrained, as expert annotation at the scale required for political constructs is expensive and time-consuming, and also prone to high inter-rater disagreement on complex rhetorical constructions [26], [27].

Embedding-based representations partially addressed these limitations, with models like Word2Vec and GloVe capturing distributional similarity between terms, though without contextualisation, as each word receives a single fixed representation regardless of discursive context [28], [29]. Transformer architectures resolved that with bidirectional contextualised self-attention and have increasingly become the standard for context-sensitive computational political text analysis, with their applications spanning inter-party communication modelling, populism detection and political hate speech identification [15], [30], [31], [32]. Large Language Models (LLMs) have these capabilities in similar contexts through zero and few-shot generalisation, though persistent concerns around interpretability and prompt sensitivity mean that fine-tuned transformers are the more methodologically transparent framework where analytical control is required [33], [34]. Across this progression however, category classification is the dominant output paradigm, which is poorly suited to constructs that are inherently graded and continuous. Mohammad et al. [35] demonstrated in the affect and emotion-intensity domain that collapsing graded variables into discrete classes introduces systematic information loss, and that regression over real-valued intensity scores gives both more theoretically faithful representations and smoother optimisation objectives.

This motivates a shared-encoder, task-specific head architecture in which a single transformer encoder learns a unified contextual representation whilst independent regression heads predict the intensity of each analytical dimension. Multi-task learning theory establishes that jointly learning related tasks reduces overfitting of the shared representation and improves generalisation because tasks use evidence from each other during training [36]. That design has been empirically validated in adjacent domains: multi-head regression architectures have been applied to jointly predicting continuous signal intensities across overlapping dimensions from weakly supervised data [37] and shared-encoder designs have been shown to capture contextual dependencies across related affective dimensions more effectively than independent task models [38].

2.2 Computational Approaches to Securitisation Analysis

Over the years the Copenhagen School framework has been refined and critiqued, with works like Balzacq [39] and Stritzel [40] arguing it underweights how audience and wider social context shape whether securitising rhetoric succeeds. However, the original formulation is appropriate for the sentence-level regression task here as it provides discrete pre-defined linguistic units to measure intensity with, and my downstream analysis engages with the audience and contextual conditions these critiques highlight through its examination of public salience and legislative co-movement.

Efforts to operationalise securitisation computationally have developed alongside the broader methodological trajectory discussed in Section 2.1, though unevenly. The earliest and most prevalent approaches measured occurrence of security-related terms using pre-defined word-count dictionaries and manually constructed lexicons to proxy securitising intent [41], [42]. Whilst these scale effectively across large corpora, they reduce securitisation to its most explicitly observable linguistic markers, treating word presence as a sufficient indicator of rhetorical function. Securitising intent is frequently conveyed through metaphor, framing and discursive positioning beyond explicit terminology, and empirical work on political rhetoric demonstrates that identical terms carry different meanings across semantic contexts, meaning dictionary counts may misrepresent the very signal they aim to capture [43], [44].

More recent work applied topic modelling to group co-occurring security-related terms into latent themes, allowing securitisation to be tracked as a shifting discourse pattern instead of a fixed vocabulary [45], [46]. However, these models measure only the extent to which the text contains security-related themes, not how threat is constructed within them. For example, a manifesto passage discussing defence spending could score highly on a security topic without actually being a securitising move whilst a passage framing immigration as an existential emergency might do so without commonplace security vocabulary. These models are therefore useful for agenda tracking but the insight they offer into the rhetorical intensity or dimensional structure of securitising moves is limited.

Word embeddings have since been applied to track how semantic associations of threat-related terms shift across time, offering richer representations than keyword counts [47], [48]. Whilst these approaches can identify when security language intensifies, they cannot determine whether that shift reflects genuine rhetorical escalation or thematic co-occurrence, as they are anchored to distributional patterns instead of rhetorical construction of individual utterances.

Yet work applying transformer architectures to securitisation is surprisingly limited; where these models do appear, like in Tasente et al. [14], they approximate constructs like discursive risk through sentiment and emotion classification instead of directly modelling securitisation's constituent dimensions. Thus there is a clear methodological gap, as no regression-based transformer models have been explicitly fine-tuned to measure securitising intensity, nor has any work jointly modelled threat construction, urgency

articulation and justificatory framing as the Copenhagen School's framework articulates them.

2.3 Corpus Choice as a Constraint on Modelling Securitising Discourse

The aforementioned methodological limitations compound further when corpus selection poorly matches the construct being modelled, as it controls both what can be analysed and the validity of any inferences that get made. Large-scale social media data is the most commonly used corpus for linking political language to public response [49], but its fit for securitisation analysis is poor. Representativeness concerns [50], [51] limit how reliably claims drawn from such samples generalise to broader political discourse, and rapid shifts in communicative norms [52] sit poorly with the structured longitudinal demands that securitisation analysis imposes.

The Manifesto Research on Political Representation (MARPOR) project offers a more suitable alternative as it provides a systematically curated and widely adopted corpus of party manifestos annotated at the quasi-sentence level into discrete policy categories [53]. It has been extensively used to support research on ideological positioning, issue salience and policy emphasis with cross-national consistency [18], [54], [55], making it the standard resource for computational analysis of party text. However, its coding scheme is designed to capture what policy positions are expressed, not the rhetorical intensity or securitising framing through which they are constructed. This is consequential because securitising discourse operates through graded rhetorical moves that discrete category labels cannot capture, and whose force frequently depends on narrative continuity that quasi-sentence segmentation obscures. Thus whilst MARPOR is a robust and well-validated resource, its annotation scheme is designed for issue salience and offers no direct supervisory signal for the rhetorical dimensions required here, so its direct application would constrain analysis to surface-level representations unless supplemented with more expressive modelling approaches.

However, the manifesto texts MARPOR provide are analytically valuable independently of their coding scheme. As institutionally grounded documents produced under full party control, they capture overarching party narratives instead of situational rhetoric of individual actors, and their deliberate and edited nature makes them highly reliable for automated analysis [12], [13], [56]. Critically for this study, their consistent availability across parties and electoral cycles enables systematic longitudinal comparisons that offer an important advantage over sources like expert judgments that lack historical comparability [57]. Researchers have shown that NLP applied to manifesto corpora can track how party ideology, framing and rhetorical emphasis evolve across electoral cycles [12], [56], and that their institutional consistency supports both temporal and cross-party comparisons [13]. Consequently, whilst existing annotation schemes constrain what can be directly inferred from a corpus, manifestos are a well-suited data source for analysing how securitising discourse develops across UK parties, provided that modelling approaches are capable of capturing rhetorical structure alongside policy content.

2.4 Lexicon-Informed Supervision and Representation Learning

Large-scale manual annotation is both resource-intensive and difficult to standardise across theoretical categories, making fully supervised approaches to complex political constructs often impractical. Weakly supervised learning offers a more scalable alternative, allowing domain knowledge to be encoded as heuristic signals and thereby reducing reliance on exhaustive labelling. Lexical resources are particularly well-suited to this role: increasingly reconceptualised as structured encodings of domain knowledge, they can serve as sources of weak supervisory signals inside modern learning pipelines [58], injecting theory-informed guidance directly into representation learning instead of functioning as static feature extractors.

This reconceptualisation is formalised by Ratner et al.'s *Data Programming* paradigm [59], where domain heuristics are expressed as labelling functions that shape model representations during training whilst leaving no trace at inference. Frameworks like *Snorkel* and *skweak* instantiate this by treating lexicons and gazetteers as the labelling functions, enabling large-scale pseudo-annotation and reducing dependence on costly manual labelling [60], [61]. The paradigm extends into representation learning more broadly: models including *SentiLARE*, *SentiX*, *SKEP* and *SoftMCL* integrate lexical knowledge during pretraining and fine-tuning to bias representations towards domain-relevant semantics [62], [63], [64], [65], whilst LOTClass and PIEClass demonstrate that lexicon-derived pseudo-labels can serve as scalable supervisory signals in place of exhaustive annotation [66], [67].

Whilst no prior work has applied this paradigm specifically to securitisation, adjacent contributions demonstrate its viability for rhetorically and ideologically grounded constructs of comparable complexity. Lexicon-derived moral signals were used in contextual topic models to capture framing dynamics over time in political discourse [68], transformer-based frame detection used codebook-driven lexical features to identify rhetorical framing devices [69] and domain-specific pretraining was used to embed specialised vocabularies for extracting security-relevant narratives [70], [71]. Further, regression-based transformers have been used to learn latent ideological dimensions from surrogate labels [72] and hybrid lexicon-supervised pipelines were applied to political security threat prediction [73]. However, these contributions are all isolated to individual dimensions of securitisation and none attempt joint modelling of threat construction, urgency and justificatory language as continuous, theoretically-grounded intensity scores.

The limitation therefore lies in integration and theoretical alignment, not methodological capability. The Data Programming paradigm offers a principled basis for addressing this by treating each dimension's lexicon as a labelling function whose pseudo-labels enter the training objective as auxiliary supervisory targets, internalising the theoretical structure into the encoder's learned representations during training. This will allow securitisation intensity to be modelled as a continuous, context-sensitive measurement that addresses both keyword approaches' confinement to explicit

lexical markers and topic models' inability to distinguish thematic salience from rhetorical construction.

2.5 Linking Securitising Discourse Shifts to Public Response

Corpus-level approaches have sought to connect political language to downstream behavioural outcomes through time-series modelling of aggregated textual features, with Kant et al. [74] demonstrating via Granger causality that shifts in threat-related language (derived from topic modelling) do precede patterns of political violence and comparable work identifying statistical associations with voter mobilisation [75] and public opinion [76]. Whilst these studies establish that language can reliably predict real-world outcomes, they rely on low-dimensional proxies like topic prevalence and binary stances that reduce complex discourse to coarse summary signals, making it difficult to isolate the specific mechanics of securitising rhetoric from broader linguistic patterns.

A separate body of work takes a more granular approach, using embedding-based methods like dynamic word embeddings and the Dynamic Embedded Topic Model to track how political terms and themes transform across eras [77], [78], [79]. These methods capture nuanced linguistic variation but tend to assume smooth and gradual discourse drift, an assumption that sits poorly with the abrupt, performative speech acts through which securitisation operates. More fundamentally, such approaches are rarely connected to external behavioural outcomes, limiting their utility for causal analysis. General frameworks for text-based causal inference [80] and forecasting [81] confirm that language can predict real-world shifts, yet neither is tailored to the structured, multi-dimensional mechanics of securitisation.

The continuous, sentence-level intensity scores produced here can be aggregated into party-level longitudinal time series, providing temporal and causal analysis with a theoretically-grounded and dimensionally structured signal that topic-level summaries cannot match. This directly addresses the fragmentation above, where studies linking political language to downstream outcomes have relied on those coarser representations whilst models capturing rich linguistic structure have remained disconnected from such outcomes.

2.6 Research Gap

Across the literature, three gaps emerge. First, there is no regression-based transformer model that jointly models threat, urgency and justificatory framing as continuous intensity scores explicitly aligned with the Copenhagen School's framework, with existing approaches either gauging securitisation through sentiment and topic proxies or addressing its dimensions in isolation. Second, whilst the Data Programming paradigm and lexicon-informed representation learning are well-established in adjacent NLP tasks, no prior work has applied theory-derived lexicons as structured auxiliary supervision within a transformer learning objective for securitisation analysis. Third, corpus-level work connecting political language to downstream societal outcomes is split between methods that establish observational links through coarse textual proxies, which miss the multi-dimensional mechanics of securitising rhetoric, and methods that do capture richer linguistic structure but stay disconnected from those outcomes.

This study addresses all three gaps through a unified, theory-aligned framework. A multi-head DeBERTa-based regression model is trained on hand-annotated manifesto sentences, with lexicon-derived pseudo-labels incorporated as auxiliary supervision to extend the training signal beyond the scale and coverage constraints of manual annotation alone. The resulting continuous, dimension-level intensity scores are aggregated into longitudinal time series, enabling structured temporal analysis of whether shifts in securitising discourse precede, follow or co-evolve with changes in public opinion salience. This constitutes the first regression-based transformer framework to model the Copenhagen School's three securitisation dimensions jointly as continuous intensity scores, addressing all three gaps within a unified, theory-aligned design.

3 Methodology

This section covers the methodology I use for measuring securitisation intensity within UK party manifestos. A multi-head DeBERTa-v3-base regression model is trained to predict sentence-level intensity across the three dimensions of the Copenhagen School's securitisation framework, namely threat articulation, urgency expression and justification of extraordinary measures. Because of the scale limitations manual annotation imposes, I supplement it by applying theory-derived lexicons to the full unlabelled corpus, generating auxiliary regression targets that supervise the encoder through a semi-supervised training loop. I evaluate a baseline alongside two configurations of this auxiliary mechanism, keeping it as the only structural variable to isolate its contribution. The rationale for selecting the final reported model is presented in Section 3.6.

3.1 Corpus and Annotation

As established in Section 2.3, UK party manifestos are well-suited for longitudinal securitisation analysis and thus I adopt them as the corpus for this study. The corpus spans six election cycles (2005–2024), capturing the period in which securitising rhetoric became more prominent within UK political discourse following 9/11 and 7/7. I retained all available party manifestos to preserve the natural distribution of political discourse across parties with varying levels of electoral participation.

My unit of measurement is a full sentence instead of MARPOR's quasi-sentences. This is because quasi-sentence segmentation often splits longer constructions in two, so for instance, a sentence like "We desperately need to stop funding illegals to prioritise funding our NHS" is a single securitising move, but MARPOR's scheme would segment that into separate immigration and welfare-policy codes that would consequently split the rhetorical connection between them.

Manifestos were fetched from the MARPOR database. Many used non-embedded fonts that corrupted the raw

PDF text, so I extracted text using Optical Character Recognition (OCR). I then ran a set of sentence-level repairs to address doubled-character runs and spaced characters from font-rendering issues, line breaks, micro-fusions of adjacent words, word reversals, metadata, headers, tables of contents and non-English sentences (Irish manifestos are duplicated in Gaelic).

I sampled 1,500 sentences by weighting each party and election cycle by their presence in the full corpus to ensure each sample reflected the underlying discourse distribution. I then labelled each of them on a 0-3 ordinal scale for each of the three securitisation dimensions (which hereafter I refer to as gold labels). Appendix A contains the codebook created and used for that. Prior to training I normalised labels to [0,1]. The resulting distribution was heavily skewed towards zero-labels, reflecting the relative rarity of high-intensity securitising language in manifesto text, which directly motivates the label distribution smoothing (LDS) I applied during training.

Urgency and justification labels were especially imbalanced, with both dimensions heavily concentrated at the lower end of the ordinal scale. To address this I ran the baseline model over a supplementary corpus of UK party manifestos from 1987 to 2001 and selected the 150 highest-scoring urgency sentences and 100 highest-scoring justification ones, manually labelling them using the same codebook. I selected these two dimensions because their high-intensity labels were the sparsest, though I annotated all three dimensions on every augmented sentence. The 250 augmented sentences were restricted to only the training partition to stop evaluation set contamination and were not used in the analysis, as pre-2005 manifestos predate the post-9/11 rhetorical context I am investigating. I partitioned the 1,500 gold sentences with a 70/15/15 split following Sechidis et al. [82], using mean intensity quartile stratification to preserve the distribution of rare high-scoring cases, and added the 250 augmented sentences exclusively to the training partition.

As no second annotator was available I measured intra-annotator agreement following Krippendorff [83] through a blind re-annotation of a 150-sentence subset (10% of the primary annotation set, seed=42) after a three-week gap. I chose Cohen's Quadratic Weighted Kappa [84] as the primary metric because its ordinal penalty structure penalises larger category discrepancies proportionally more than adjacent ones, making it well-suited to graded securitisation intensity scores. Threat, urgency and justification achieved QWK scores of 0.783, 0.704 and 0.800 respectively (macro-average 0.762), placing all three dimensions in the "substantial" agreement band [85]. Within-one agreement exceeded 98.7% across all dimensions. Urgency's comparatively lower score is consistent with its tricky context-dependent nature and partially contextualises its weak performance relative to the other dimensions (reported in Section 4.2).

3.2 Tiered Securitisation Lexicons

I constructed three theory-derived lexicons (one per securitisation dimension) to provide auxiliary supervision targets grounded in domain knowledge, as no existing resource provides intensity-sensitive, multi-dimensional coverage aligned with the Copenhagen School's framework. Although Baele and Sterck's Security Lexicon [86] does provide validated hard-security vocabulary, it focuses on threat construction and does not further decompose securitisation into the urgency and justificatory dimensions needed, so I therefore created dimension-specific lexicons to align supervision with the underlying theoretical criteria. The finalised lexicons have 490 terms for threat (152 core, 232 secondary, 106 contextual), 233 for justification (65 core, 89 secondary, 79 contextual) and 94 for urgency (37 core, 40 secondary, 17 contextual), with the smaller urgency lexicon reflecting the structural difficulty of capturing modal and syntactic constructions through vocabulary matching alone.

I group the lexicon terms into three categories to capture varying levels of rhetorical intensity. This draws on Baele and Rousseau's [41] work, who create a distinction between generic securitising vocabulary, which evokes threat irrespective of context, and "contingent" terms whose securitising power depends on how they resonate in context. I extend this into a three-level grading applied to each dimension, in which core terms unambiguously enact securitisation, secondary terms intensify or legitimise a securitising move and contextual terms become securitising only in the context of historical analogies, cultural resonance or specific domain framing. Each dimension has its own grading criteria to reflect its distinct rhetorical logic, summarised in Table 1.

These lexicons were constructed in three stages. I first created a list of seed terms from foundational securitisation literature including [6], [41], [87]. These included single and multi-word phrases as well as figurative devices like threat metaphors and historical analogies, which Baele and Rousseau [41] argue are central to securitising rhetoric. Second, I expanded these using Baele and Sterck's [86] Security Lexicon, a 222-term validated hard-security dictionary. Terms were deduplicated, stemmed entries expanded and all additions manually vetted before being assigned to dimensions and tiered according to Table 1.

Third, I applied SBERT [88] for corpus-grounded expansion following Bommasani et al. [89], embedding each candidate unigram and bigram from the corpus using `all-mpnet-base-v2` by averaging contextual representations across all sentences the term appeared in to produce representations grounded in UK political usage. To rank candidates I calculated the dimension centroids for the seed lexicon embeddings and measured the cosine similarity of each term. For bigrams, I opted for log-likelihood over PMI, as it prevents the model from over-prioritising terms that appear frequently in a single manifesto but lack the cross-party footprint needed to be general indicators of securitisation. Thresholds were selected for each dimension (99th for threat, 99.5th for urgency, 99.7th for justification) by raising the percentile until fewer than 30% of the bottom 50 marginal candidates showed semantic drift from their dimension's theoretical definition. All candidates above the selected threshold were then manually validated against the criteria in Table 1. This stage added 60 terms to the threat lexicon (24 core, 26 secondary, 10 contextual), 15 to urgency (5 core, 5 secondary, 5 contextual) and 23 to justification (5 core, 17 secondary, 1 contextual).

The variation in thresholds showed that threat was the most effective dimension for this. Examining the accepted

TABLE 1
Tier definitions and examples of corresponding vocabulary per securitisation dimension.

Tier	Threat	Urgency	Justification
Core	Survival vocabulary; implies serious threat without context (*existential threat, war, extinction*)	Immediacy vocabulary; explicitly collapses decision timeframe (*urgent, point of no return, ticking clock*)	Suspension vocabulary; directly invokes emergency authority (*martial law, curfew, interdiction*)
Secondary	Hostility vocabulary; constructs self-other dichotomy (*enemy, infiltrating, brutal*)	Priority vocabulary & escalation; elevates issue above others (*unprecedented, paramount, irreversible*)	Duty vocabulary; invokes institutional legitimacy, moral obligation or decisive action (*solemn duty, sovereignty, enforce*)
Contextual	Vulnerability vocabulary; historical analogies and thick signifiers (*9/11, the Blitz, wave*)	Commitment and insistence vocabulary; signals strong intent without explicit time pressure (*ensure, demand, tackle*)	Boundary management vocabulary; policy mechanisms deployed in securitising rhetoric (*surveillance, crackdown, sanction*)

terms revealed that its securitising vocabulary was relatively clear-cut and semantically similar to the seed terms, which was less the case for urgency and justification. Urgency is often communicated with modal verbs and time-bound syntactic constructions that resist clean lexicon mapping. Modal verbs (e.g. *must, shall, cannot*) are too generic to include without matching a lot of false-positive matches and syntactic constructions (*must act now* or *time is running out*) are too large and varied to capture as fixed terms. Justification is similar, as justificatory constructions are often conveyed at clause level. For instance, *whatever it takes* or *without parliamentary delay* would both resist discovery through single-term similarity. For those two dimensions the embedding model captured terms with similar topics well but was less effective at identifying terms whose securitising force is more reliant on context. As a result, the auxiliary training signal derived from the lexicons is weakest on these dimensions, which makes gold-labelled annotation the more reliable supervisory source.

Section 3.3 describes how I apply these finalised lexicons to generate continuous pseudo-labels for the unlabelled corpus.

3.3 Weak Supervision Pipeline

Using the Data Programming paradigm discussed in Section 2.4 [59], I applied lexicons as dimension-specific labelling functions across the full unlabelled corpus of $\sim$44,000 manifesto sentences, using a greedy longest-match scan where multi-word phrases take precedence over constituent unigrams to avoid double-counting (e.g. "world war" takes precedence over "war"). Each match contributes a tier-weighted count, with core matches weighted 3, secondary 1.5, contextual 0.75 and no match 0.0 to reflect the theoretical intensity hierarchy from Section 3.2. Scores were length-normalised by taking the square root of token count and transformed via

$$\hat{y} = 1 - \exp(-kS), \quad k = 1.2 \tag{1}$$

so repeated matches give diminishing returns. The output values are in $[0, 1]$, the same range as the normalised gold labels. I chose k=1.2 to ensure that a single strong lexicon match maps onto a moderately confident pseudo-label whilst additional matches provide diminishing returns, and held that value fixed throughout. These pseudo-labels form the weak pool for the semi-supervised training loop described in Section 3.5 and are not used at inference.

Calibration against the gold set shows that pseudo-labels carry statistically significant directional signal across all dimensions, with the strongest lexicon-gold alignment for threat (Spearman ρ=0.467), followed by justification (ρ=0.381) and urgency (ρ=0.346). Lexicon coverage of the corpus was modest across dimensions at 14-18%, which reflects the limitations of vocabulary matching for constructs that are often expressed through syntactic and clause-level patterns. This ordering is consistent with my SBERT expansion findings of Section 3.2 and motivates the auxiliary supervision configurations evaluated in Section 3.6.

3.4 Model Architecture

The model architecture (Figure 1) is based on a DeBERTa-v3-base encoder (hidden size 768) that produces contextualised token representations which are aggregated by mean-pooling over non-padding tokens. I use mean pooling over CLS-token extraction following Reimers and Gurevych [88] because it gives stronger sentence-level representations for tasks requiring whole-sentence understanding, which matters in this context because securitising cues can appear at any position within a sentence and mean pooling them ensures each token will equally contribute to representation of the sentence.

That mean-pooled representation feeds into three independent regression heads (one per securitisation dimension) that each apply LayerNorm followed by $K = 2$ independently masked dropout forward passes ($p = 0.3$) whose predictions are averaged before loss is computed. Following Inoue [90], this multi-sample dropout scheme discourages the model from relying on a single activation pattern and is a computationally cheap approximation to ensemble regularisation, which is needed given the small gold set. Each of the heads are two-layer MLPs (hidden $\rightarrow$ hidden/2 via GELU, then $\rightarrow$ 1 via sigmoid), bounding all outputs to $[0, 1]$.

For auxiliary variants I extend the shared encoder with additional heads of the same structure that are trained

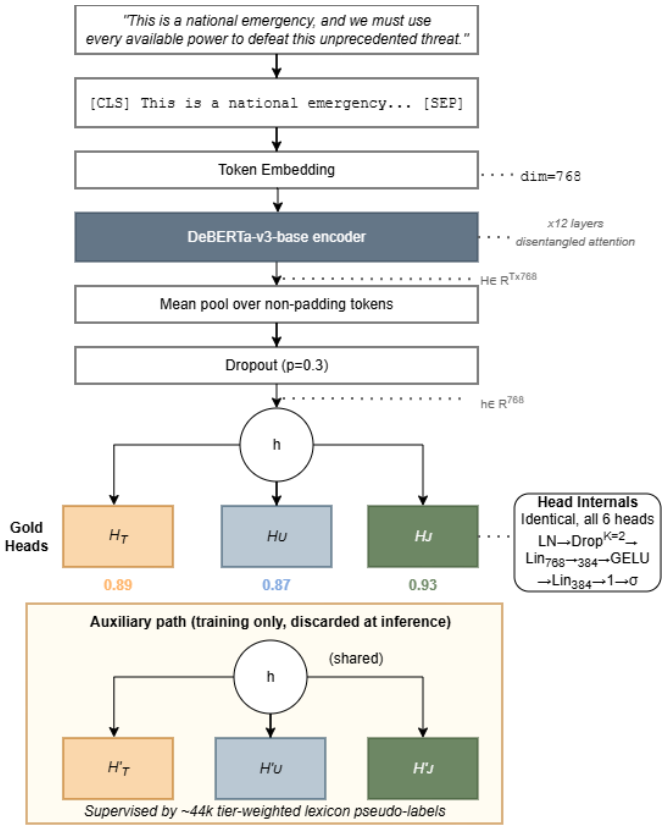


Fig. 1. Architecture of the multi-head DeBERTa-v3-base intensity regression model (full auxiliary variant). Training objective $L_{total} = L_{gold} + \lambda_{aux}L_{aux} + \lambda_{rdrop}L_{rdrop}$ ($\lambda_{aux} = 0.5$, $\lambda_{rdrop} = 0.1$). L_{gold} is SmoothL1 with LDS reweighting over the ∼1.3k gold-labelled training sentences, with loss computed on the average of two independently masked forward passes. L_{rdrop} is the MSE between those two passes' predictions (R-Drop). L_{aux} is SmoothL1 on the weak pool of ∼44k lexicon-labelled sentences at a 6:1 weak-to-gold batch ratio.

to predict the corresponding lexicon-derived pseudo-label, creating a compatible gradient signal from both supervision sources that is consistent with the canonical multi-task learning framework of Caruana [91] that Liu et al. [92] extended to transformer architectures. All auxiliary heads are discarded at inference so that all variants have the same output signature. The specific configurations, alongside the rationale for each, are set out in Section 3.6.

3.5 Training Configuration

All three models share identical training configuration, with the supervision mechanism being the only structural difference. I train the baseline with $L = L_{gold} + \lambda_{rdrop} \times L_{rdrop}$, where L_{gold} is a SmoothL1 regression loss over gold labels and L_{rdrop} implements R-Drop regularisation [93] as the MSE between two independent dropout-masked forward passes ($\lambda_{rdrop} = 0.1$). The auxiliary variants extend that training with a separate weak pool pathway inside which the unlabelled corpus sentences are processed through auxiliary regression heads to contribute $\lambda_{aux_weak} \times L_{aux}$ to the shared encoder's gradient, whilst gold batches stay identical to baseline.

Before training I remove gold-labelled sentences from the weak pool to prevent the auxiliary heads from receiving gradient on sentences also supervised by gold labels. The full auxiliary variant applies this filtering across all three dimensions simultaneously and the selective variant restricts auxiliary supervision to threat alone. Both process six weak batches per gold batch. λ_{aux_weak}=0.50 was fixed following preliminary validation-set experimentation and held constant across both auxiliary variants for the cross-validation reported in Section 4.1. I then confirmed that selection by ablating over {0, 0.05, 0.10, 0.15, 0.25, 0.35, 0.45, 0.50, 0.60, 0.75} on the selected variant, keeping 0.50 as the final value because it performed best on urgency (the weakest dimension).

I reweight per-sample losses using label distribution smoothing (LDS) [94] to address the zero-skewed concentration in the training labels, using a Gaussian-smoothed inverse-frequency estimate over the training distribution to assign higher weight to the rarer high-intensity sentences that otherwise would be dominated by the low tier labels. Urgency and justification dimensions were given a fixed loss weight of 1.75 relative to threat at 1.0 to compensate for their lower label frequency and the weaker training signal from their lexicons. The optimiser is AdamW (weight decay 0.01) with layer-wise learning rate decay [95] at factor 0.9 from a base rate of 2×10^{-5}, following Sun et al.'s [96] BERT fine-tuning recommendations. Linear warmup runs for 10% of steps, after which cosine decay takes over. I apply gradient clipping (max norm 1.0), mixed-precision training [97] and gradient accumulation over two steps to give an effective batch size of 16. Early stopping monitors validation loss with patience 5.

3.6 Experimental Design

I evaluate two auxiliary configurations that extend the baseline. Both were designed to find out if lexicon-derived supervision improves on gold-only training and, how, if so, lexicon-gold alignment quality shapes that improvement. The full auxiliary variant applies all three dimension lexicons simultaneously despite the weaker alignment on urgency ($\rho = 0.346$) and justification ($\rho = 0.381$). The idea here is that even moderate-quality pseudo-labels on a large scale might be able to broaden the encoder's representation enough to be useful. The selective variant restricts auxiliary supervision to threat alone ($\rho = 0.467$) to test whether focusing the gradient on just the strongest signal avoids the noise the weaker lexicons might amplify.

To assess metric stability across the small gold set I ran 5-fold cross-validation for all three models, stratifying folds by mean intensity quartile to preserve the distribution of high-intensity examples across partitions and using Spearman ρ as the primary metric as the downstream temporal analysis depends on correct rank-ordering of securitisation intensity across sentences. LDS weights were recomputed per fold to prevent density estimate leakage across partitions and augmented sentences were kept in each fold's training partition consistent with the treatment I describe in Section 3.1. Cross-validation results comparing both auxiliary configurations against the baseline are reported in Section 4.1 and examples of the model's predictions across a range of sentence types are presented in Appendix C.

3.7 Temporal Analysis

I apply the full auxiliary model to the whole 2005–2024 manifesto corpus, including sentences used for training and evaluation, to produce sentence-level securitisation scores which I then aggregate to the party-election level for downstream temporal analysis. As the Copenhagen School defines a securitising move as requiring the simultaneous presence of threat, urgency and justification, I define the composite score as the minimum across all three predicted dimensions. The main aggregate is the proportion of sentences per party-election manifesto scoring at or above 0.14 on this composite, referred to throughout as the composite exceedance rate. 0.14 was selected as a conservative lower-bound signal detector which I calibrated through bottom-up manual inspection of the model's lowest-scoring predictions. At this value the false positive rate across the lowest-scoring 50 predictions was under 15% and a complementary inspection of the highest-scoring 50 sentences found just a 4% false negative rate, so the findings I draw from this series are a conservative lower bound instead of a precise count of discrete securitising acts. At this threshold the false positives are sparse and unrelated to one another. Underprediction is the safer error mode here because the aim is to identify genuine rhetorical signal over just maximising recall.

Public salience is drawn from the Ipsos Issues Index, a monthly unprompted survey series that asks respondents to name the single biggest issue facing Britain along with any others they consider important, tracking the combined share of mentions per issue [98]. I compare this salience against a curated set of 24 Acts (detailed in Appendix D) that I classify as securitising under the Copenhagen School framework. This list is not necessarily exhaustive of all UK legislation with civil-liberties implications in the study period but it is the set I judge as most clearly securitising.

The Copenhagen School organises securitisation into five sectors, namely Military, Societal, Environmental, Economic and Political, and I keep this structure across both data sources because securitisation operates differently between sectors and aggregating salience would obscure how each Act aligns with its sector. I therefore map an Ipsos series to each sector, using defence and terrorism salience for Military, immigration for Societal, pollution and environment for Environmental, economic situation for Economic and Common Market, EU and Brexit for Political.

To address my two research questions I run a temporal analysis consisting of two complementary approaches. The first approach asks whether securitising rhetoric has converged across parties and electoral cycles. To examine this I plot composite exceedance trajectories for the four major parties, with the broader parliamentary field backgrounded for context. I then decompose the four majors' above-threshold sentences dimension by dimension, so shifts in any one dimension show up where the composite's minimum-based formulation would otherwise mask it. A heatmap of parties per election then widens the view to the full parliamentary field so I can compare patterns from the four majors against the smaller parties.

Then the second approach addresses the temporal-relationship question, examining how shifts in party-level rhetoric relate temporally to public opinion salience and to securitising legislation. For this I overlay the legislation timeline of the 24 Copenhagen-School-classified Acts against each sector's corresponding Ipsos salience series to look for patterns of temporal alignment between public concern and legislative output. Then I compare the incumbent party's exceedance rate against the opposition mean at each election alongside Acts enacted during that parliament, following prior work linking manifesto rhetoric to downstream legislative outcomes [9], because legislation is sponsored and carried by the governing party not the parliamentary field as a whole. However, with only six elections in the study window, I treat observed alignments between rhetoric, salience and legislative output as correlational, not causal. This allows me to identify and interpret patterns even without the sample size needed to formally establish temporal precedence.

4 Results

In this section I present cross-validation stability across all three model variants followed by an overview of my selected model's held-out test performance. I then go on to describe the descriptive temporal patterns that stand out from applying my selected model to the full manifesto corpus.

4.1 Cross-Validation Model Comparison

Table 2 shows the results of 5-fold cross-validation ran on all three model variants at a macro level and then broken down into the three securitisation dimension's individual performances. All folds used identical stratification, LDS recomputation and augmentation handling.

TABLE 2
5-fold cross-validation results (mean ± std across folds).

Metric	Baseline	Full Aux	Threat-Only
Macro Spearman ρ	$0.461 \pm .031$	$\mathbf{0.487 \pm .016}$	$0.466 \pm .021$
Threat ρ	$0.611 \pm .028$	$0.625 \pm .048$	$\mathbf{0.628 \pm .039}$
Urgency ρ	$0.363 \pm .078$	$\mathbf{0.410 \pm .055}$	$0.379 \pm .058$
Justification ρ	$0.408 \pm .046$	$\mathbf{0.424 \pm .020}$	$0.391 \pm .027$
Macro Pearson r	$0.609 \pm .040$	$\mathbf{0.633 \pm .031}$	$0.600 \pm .028$
Macro QWK	$0.554 \pm .040$	$\mathbf{0.585 \pm .039}$	$0.534 \pm .041$

All models evaluated under identical stratification, LDS recomputation and augmentation handling. Best mean per metric in bold.

The full auxiliary variant outperforms both the baseline (macro Spearman 0.461 ± 0.031) and selective threat-only variant (0.466 ± 0.021) across folds, reaching 0.487 ± 0.016 with the gain concentrated primarily on urgency, the dimension that was most in need of improvement. It outperforms baseline on $4/5$ folds, with the one marginal outlier within fold-level noise at -0.008 macro difference. It also achieves the lowest fold-to-fold variance of the three configurations through a standard deviation 48% lower than baseline, which indicates the semi-supervised mechanism adds to the model in a way that makes it both reliably stronger and also more stable across folds.

At the dimension level urgency shows the largest single-dimension improvement of any model pair (+0.047 over baseline, from 0.363 to 0.410), which is noteworthy given the urgency lexicon has the weakest gold alignment (Spearman ρ = 0.346) and the smallest term count of the three

dimensions at 94 terms. Urgency is also the most volatile dimension across all configurations, with standard deviations exceeding 0.05 in every model, though the full auxiliary variant reduces this from 0.078 (baseline) to 0.055, a 30% reduction in fold-to-fold instability. The fold-level pattern holds across architectures, with the same folds producing low and high scores regardless of supervision mechanism, confirming this remaining variance as a property of the data partitioning, not the model itself. Threat and justification both improve modestly over baseline (+0.014 and +0.016 respectively).

The selective auxiliary variant shows no effective difference from the full variant on threat itself (+0.003, well within fold-level standard deviation) and does not outperform it on any aggregate metric or on the other two dimensions, despite threat's stronger lexicon-gold alignment. This suggests that even moderately aligned pseudo-labels on urgency and justification contribute useful representational diversity to the shared encoder when delivered at sufficient volume through the semi-supervised training loop. I retain this variant in the comparison to demonstrate that dimension-selective supervision is not the optimal strategy for this task, contrary to my initial expectation motivated by the lexicon alignment analysis in Section 3.3.

Thus based off these results I select the full auxiliary variant as the final reported model. I report the held-out evaluation for this in Section 4.2, and conduct the temporal analysis in Section 4.3 using it.

4.2 Selected Model Performance

The full auxiliary model scores a macro Spearman of 0.524 on the held-out test set. Threat is the strongest dimension at $\rho = 0.661$, followed by justification at $\rho = 0.526$ and urgency $\rho = 0.384$. Macro QWK reached 0.623, placing overall model-human agreement in the "substantial" band on the Landis and Koch (1977) scale [85] and approaching the intra-annotator reliability Section 3.1 reports (macro QWK 0.762). On threat the model scores 0.782 against the 0.783 intra-annotator benchmark, matching human-level consistency on this dimension. Justification scores the lowest QWK at 0.500 but the strongest Spearman of the non-threat dimensions $\rho = 0.526$, suggesting the model captured justification's rank-ordering better than its absolute intensity. Urgency was the weakest dimension on Spearman $\rho = 0.384$ but scores a QWK of 0.588. This suggests the model recognised the general intensity of urgency sentences but it struggled to grade them finely against each other. For both urgency and justification, these results are consistent with the structural limitations of sentence-level modelling for constructs that are often conveyed through whole-sentence-level context (discussed in Section 3.2). Test-set macro Spearman (0.524) is 0.037 above the cross-validation mean, which is comfortably inside the range of fold-to-fold variability and supports that the model generalised beyond the training partition.

4.3 Temporal Patterns

I apply the chosen full auxiliary model to the entire manifesto corpus and then aggregate its sentence predictions to party-election level following the approach I laid out in Section 3.7. In this analysis I use composite exceedance rate as the primary measure and track its shift over study window's six general elections. Throughout this section my descriptions are kept intentionally observational, and I save my interpretations against the research questions for Section 5.

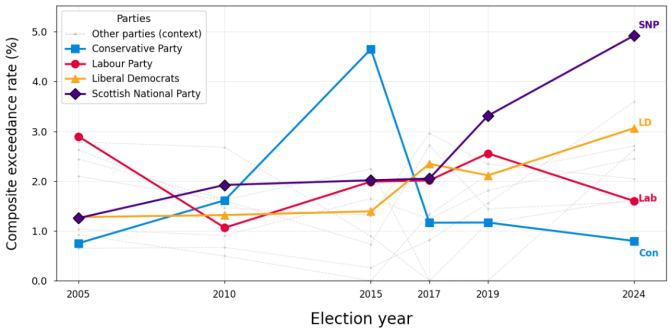


Fig. 2. Composite exceedance rate for the four major parties (coloured) and the remaining consistent parties (grey), 2005–2024.

Figure 2 plots the composite exceedance rate across the study window, with the four major parties (Conservative, Labour, Liberal Democrats and Scottish National Party (SNP)) highlighted because they maintained continuous parliamentary representation and substantial Westminster seats throughout. The remaining consistent parties are shown in grey so the movement of the broader parliamentary field can be compared against the majors. The major's exceedance rates vary from 0.8–4.9% across the study.

The clearest trajectory is the SNP, who rose from 1.3% in 2005 to 4.9% in 2024. Labour underwent a net decline, going from a 2.9% peak in 2005 to 1.6% in 2024, although they had a mid-study recovery peaking at 2.6% in 2019 before their 2024 fall. The Conservatives consistently stayed low across most elections apart from a single spike to 4.7% in 2015, which is the second-highest manifesto score and is a clear deviation from their baseline of $\sim$1%. The Liberal Democrats rose gradually from 1.3% to 3.1% across the study window. There was a brief convergence of the four trajectories in 2017 before they diverged again, with the 2024 spread being the widest of any election in the study window.

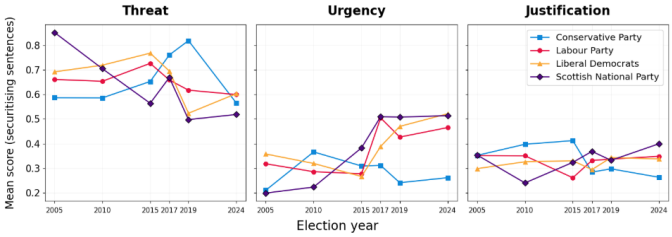


Fig. 3. Mean threat, urgency and justification intensity among securitising sentences for the four major parties across the six elections

Figure 3 decomposes the composite trajectories in Figure 2 into the three constituent dimensions aggregated across the above-threshold sentences at each election. The following analysis describes each of the three dimensions and then highlights two distinct party trajectories.

Firstly, threat is tightly clustered across the four parties, staying roughly parallel throughout the study window and then converging in 2024 inside a 0.52–0.60 range, which is

the tightest dimensional spread despite 2024 being the year of widest composite divergence (Figure 2). Urgency shows asymmetric convergence, with Labour, Liberal Democrats and SNP all rising to the 0.47–0.52 range by 2024 whilst the Conservatives declined from 0.37 in 2010 to 0.26 in 2024, which left them at the lowest urgency level of any major party in 2024. Justification follows the same asymmetric structure but on a narrower scale, with the Conservatives declining from 0.40 in 2010 to 0.26 in 2024 against the other three majors staying within a 0.34–0.40 range at 2024.

Two party trajectories stand out as particularly interesting. First is the Conservatives, with their 2015 spike (Figure 2) not aligning clearly with a dimensional peak on any panel here. Conservative's 2015 justification (0.41) is the largest value reached by any major party, although it is barely above their 2010 value of 0.40, and their threat and urgency scores also had just a marginal shift (threat 0.59→0.65, urgency 0.37→0.31). The proportion of the manifesto crossing the composite exceedance threshold nearly tripled across these two elections (1.6% to 4.7%), indicating that the 2015 spike was driven by a larger share of securitising sentences, not a sharpening of their rhetorical register. The SNP have the most pronounced dimensional shift across the period, moving from a high-threat low-urgency profile in the early elections to a balanced threat-and-urgency profile by 2024, with urgency plateauing at 0.51 from 2017 onwards. Their rising composite exceedance is carried by an urgency rise across their securitising sentences, not simply a greater share of those sentences at their previous intensity.

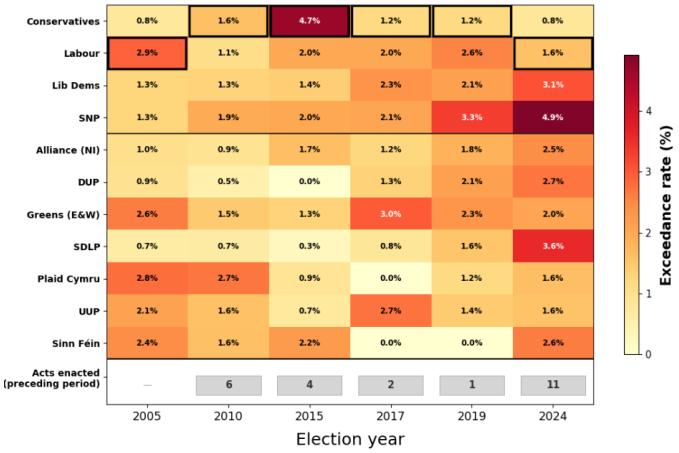


Fig. 4. Composite exceedance heatmap for the eleven consistent parties, 2005–2024. Incumbents marked with black borders and count of securitising Acts per parliament shown beneath party rows.

Figure 4 extends the analysis to the eleven consistent parties across the study window, with the incumbent (governing party at that election) marked with black borders and the count of securitising Acts enacted during each preceding parliament shown beneath the party rows. The 2019 to 2024 inter-election period had 11 securitising Acts, which was the single densest legislative period in the study window and all enacted under Conservative incumbency. Interestingly, this followed a Conservative 2019 manifesto at just 1.2% composite exceedance, which is the lowest opening rhetoric under which any incumbent governed across the study window. A similar legislative concentration manifests in the 2005-2010 parliament under Labour incumbency with 6 Acts, whilst the three intervening parliaments produced just 4, 2 and 1 Acts respectively. The two denser legislative periods therefore occur at either end of the study window, each enacted by an incumbent losing office at the election that closed the parliament.

Amongst the smaller parties the clearest trend is a rise in composite exceedance across four of the five Northern Irish parties towards the end of the study window. The Social Democratic and Labour Party (SDLP) climbed from 0.7% in 2005 to 3.6% in 2024, the Democratic Unionist Party (DUP) from 0.9% to 2.7%, the Alliance Party 1.0% to 2.5% and Sinn Féin 2.4% to 2.6% (although dropping to 0.0% in 2017 and 2019), each reaching their study-window peak in 2024. The Ulster Unionist Party (UUP) and remaining smaller parties show less directional patterns across the period.

5 Evaluation

5.1 Convergence & Divergence in Securitising Rhetoric

The first research question asks to what extent UK political party manifestos post-9/11 exhibit rhetorical convergence in securitising language across parties and elections. The evidence in Section 4.3 does not support a convergence interpretation, in fact showing divergence across the latter half of the study. The four major parties stayed in a narrow range of composite exceedance rates between 2005 and 2015, with the Conservative 2015 spike the only substantial deviation from that, before parties diverged from 2017 onwards and reached their widest cross-party spread in 2024, with all four major parties separated across a 4.1% range.

On the dimension level threat articulation converges across all four parties whilst urgency expression and justification both show those three rising together as the Conservatives decline. Urgency in particular carries this split, with the Conservative trajectory falling from 0.37 in 2010 to 0.26 in 2024 against the other three majors clustering at 0.47 to 0.52. However, I interpret this urgency-led reading with a degree of caution given urgency is the model's weakest dimension and thus produces noisier between-party magnitudes than threat or justification.

The SNP's trajectory carries further nuance. Whilst they have the largest net composite exceedance rise across the period, its nature shifts from a distinct early profile of high threat and low urgency to a 2024 profile broadly aligned with Labour and the Liberal Democrats. Thus whilst the 2024 spread amongst these three parties is volume-driven, their securitising sentences are conveyed on a shared structural profile. The Conservatives are the only party departing from that, securitising far less and using a distinct profile of high threat intensity and very low urgency and justification.

However, the Northern Irish parties cut against this divergence pattern. Four of the five reached their study-window peaks in composite exceedance at 2024, with UUP being the only one trending downward over the period. The Northern Irish field therefore shows a late-period intensification across most of its parties, contrasting with the simultaneous divergence among the four majors and indicating that the divergence verdict is specific to the major

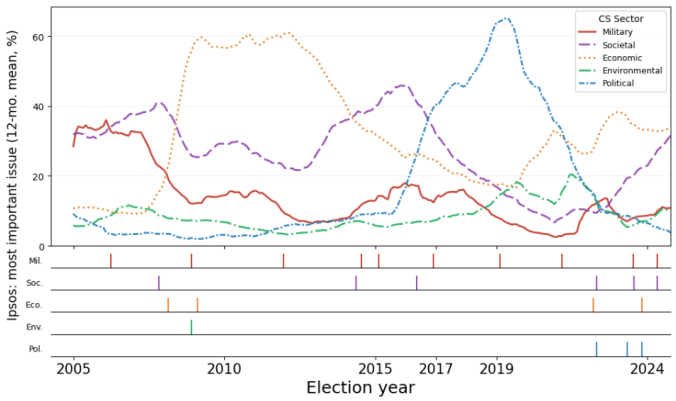


Fig. 5. Public issue salience across the five Copenhagen School sectors, 2005-2024. A twelve-month centred rolling mean is applied to suppress monthly sampling noise whilst preserving multi-year shifts. The rug beneath marks each Act's enactment date by sector. Data: Ipsos Issues Index [98].

parties and not necessarily characteristic of the broader parliamentary field.

5.2 Rhetoric, Legislation & Public Opinion

The second research question asks how the shifts in party-level securitising discourse analysed above relate temporally to public issue salience (measured here as the proportion of survey respondents identifying a given issue as amongst the most important facing Britain) and to the record of securitising laws. I treat observed alignments as correlational given the many factors beyond rhetoric and issue salience that could shape legislative output.

TABLE 3
Parliamentary rhetoric, incumbent rank and Acts per parliament.

Period	Inc.	Inc. rhet %	Op. rhet %	Rank	Acts	Sectors
2005–2010	Lab	2.90	1.66	1/4	6	Eco, Env, Mil, Soc
2010–2015	Con	1.62	1.47	2/4	4	Mil, Soc
2015–2017	Con	4.65	1.39	1/4	2	Mil, Soc
2017–2019	Con	1.16	1.57	4/4	1	Mil
2019–2024	Con	1.17	1.81	4/4	11	Eco, Mil, Pol, Soc

Inc.=Incumbent, Op.=Opposition. The rhet % columns show composite exceedance rates for the incumbent party and the opposition mean. Rank gives the incumbent's position amongst the four majors at the election opening each parliament. Sectors: Mil=Military, Soc=Societal, Env=Environmental, Eco=Economic, Pol=Political. Acts are attributed to the parliament that passes them, so each legislative row's output shows the starting-year incumbent, not the ending-year one.

Figure 5 plots each sector's Ipsos salience series with sector-coded legislation ticks marking when Acts came into law. Table 3 pairs each electoral period with the incumbent's composite exceedance rate, opposition mean rate, the incumbent's rank amongst the four majors and the number of Acts enacted during that parliament.

Starting with the 2005-2010 parliament and Labour's only incumbency, Table 3 shows their manifesto at 2.90% composite exceedance (their highest in the study) against a 1.66% opposition mean. The parliament produced six Acts across four sectors, several of which pair closely with their corresponding sector salience. In the Military sector Terrorism Act 2006 was enacted as Military salience climbed to its study-window peak of 36% in 2006, with the Counter-Terrorism Act 2008 following later as that salience receded. In the Economic sector, the two Banking Acts of 2008 and 2009 were enacted alongside a steep rise in economic salience from around 10% to 60% as the financial crisis unfolded. In the Societal sector the UK Borders Act 2007 coincided with the parliament's Societal salience peak of 40%, and in the Environmental sector the Climate Change Act 2008 was enacted at low and broadly flat environmental salience. That combination of high incumbent rhetoric, high legislative throughput and tight Military and Economic salience pairings is not repeated elsewhere, but with only one Labour parliament the pattern is descriptive only.

Across the four Conservative manifestos the composite exceedance rate fell from 1.62% to 1.17%, with a 2015 spike to 4.65% (identified in Section 5.1 as a concentration increase, not rhetorical escalation). Their rank amongst the four majors slipped from 2/4 in 2010 to 4/4 in both 2017 and 2019, leaving them with the weakest composite rhetoric of any major party across the last two electoral periods. Excluding 2015, the opposition mean rose from 1.47% in 2010 to 1.81% in 2019 whilst the incumbent rate fell, showing an inverse movement between the two.

Securitising legislation is concentrated at the endpoints of the incumbency (four and eleven Acts in 2010-2015 and 2019-2024 respectively) but this trajectory is not monotonic. The 2017-2019 parliament enacted just one Act at almost identical incumbent rhetoric to 2019-2024, though its two-year length against the following five limits the comparison. Section 5.1 identified an urgency-expression split across the 2015-2024 period, with the Conservatives declining and opposition rising. Reading that alongside the legislative arc, the trajectory speculatively suggests an inverted dynamic in which Conservatives moved towards lower rhetorical urgency whilst their securitising legislative output grew, which is the opposite direction expected if rhetoric were a primary indicator of legislative action.

Two sector patterns persist across this incumbency. First, Military salience was amongst the lowest of the five sectors post-2010 and never got close to the 36% 2006 peak under Labour incumbency, but eight Military Acts were enacted, which suggests this sector's legislative agenda was set largely independently of the public's concern with it. In contrast, the five Societal Acts enacted all coincided with rising or elevated Societal salience, which suggests there is a more responsive relationship between public concern and legislation in this sector.

The 2019 to 2024 parliament is where both patterns are most prominent, with eleven Acts enacted across four sectors of varying salience. Military salience stayed within a low 2.5%–13.6% band whilst four Military Acts were enacted, the highest of any incumbency. The three Societal Acts (Nationality and Borders 2022, Illegal Migration 2023, Safety of Rwanda 2024) were all immigration-policy-related and arrived during a sharp and likely immigration-driven Societal salience recovery from the 2020 trough, rising from 9.5% to 27.4% across the three enactment dates. The three Political Acts, covering protest restriction and digital regulation, arrived at Political salience of under 13%, well below the 2019 Brexit-era peak of 65% that had long receded by the time they were enacted. The two Economic Acts (Economic

Crime Act 2022, Energy Act 2023) were both legislative responses to Russia's invasion of Ukraine, enacted within a rising economic salience likely in-part triggered by the same shock. Across these four sectors Societal and Economic legislation co-occur with rising salience signals whilst Military and Political legislation arrive independently of theirs.

Overall, the evidence does not describe a single relationship between party-level securitising discourse, public issue salience and legislation, but one that differs by incumbent and sector. The rhetoric-to-legislation relationship shifts between the Labour and Conservative incumbencies whilst the salience-to-legislation relationship is more stable across both, but still partial.

5.3 Limitation & Methodology Critique

The framework operationalises securitisation as continuous rhetorical intensity at the speech act level, which captures just one part of the broader securitising process described by the Copenhagen School, in which a move is treated as successful only when an audience accepts the framing. Although the cross-sector correlations (Section 5.2) give an indirect signal of this uptake at the population and institutional levels, they capture co-movement, not audience acceptance in the theoretical sense. That co-movement is also open to readings I cannot infer inside this project's scope. Military legislation's apparent independence from Military salience, for instance, could equally reflect sustained post-9/11 counter-terrorism legislation lowering public concern by signalling the issue was being addressed instead of legislation operating independently of it.

At the data and annotation level, three main constraints bound my model's analytical scope. First, the lexicons imperfectly cover all three dimensions, with urgency the least well-captured because the modal and syntactic constructions political actors use to convey it resist lexicon supervision more than threat or justification do. Second, annotation was conducted solely by me, which limits the available reliability benchmark to intra-annotator agreement and prevents an inter-annotator agreement measurement. Third, the gold-set's moderate size limits the model's exposure to high-intensity examples which, despite pre-2005 augmentation (Section 3.1), are still sparse given securitising rhetoric is comparatively rare in manifestos. Combined with the strict 0.14 composite threshold, this sparsity produces low composite exceedance rates. Thus my analytical claims describe rhetorical patterns inside a strict detection regime instead of securitisation's absolute prevalence in UK manifesto discourse.

Additionally, two architectural choices further bound what the model can capture. First, sentence-level processing constrains the model's access to discourse-level context that could carry securitising force across clause boundaries, which compounds the urgency lexicon's coverage problem because its aforementioned syntactic patterns can often play out across multiple clauses and therefore go undetected even where lexicon matches occur in a single sentence. Second, the composite (min) aggregation surfaces only sentences where all three dimensions register relatively strongly, so urgency's weaker model performance disproportionately determines which sentences clear the threshold.

What's more, the depth of the temporal analysis is limited by the nature of the data I have available. First, the legislation set I created carries a degree of subjectivity and is not exhaustive, so the observed patterns are bounded by this selection. Second, the Ipsos Issues Index categories do not perfectly map onto the five securitisation sub-sectors, particularly the Political sector where I use Common Market, EU and Brexit salience as the closest proxy because it is the longest-running series tracking concern about state authority and governance. The three Political Acts (covering protest restriction and online regulation) follow a related theme of state authority over civic and digital space but are not directly Brexit-related, so this series should be read as a broader indicator of the Political sector, not a tight match to these specific Acts. Third, the study's six general elections place a ceiling on what formal time-series inference can support. Methods like Granger causality testing would be the natural fit for identifying temporal relationships between political language and downstream outcomes, as applied in comparable work [74], but need a longer time series than available here.

6 Conclusion

This project set out to investigate two research questions on post-9/11 UK political party manifestos. The first was to examine whether securitising rhetoric has converged across parties and electoral cycles and the second was to discover how any observed shifts in party-level rhetoric relate temporally to public opinion salience and to securitising legislation criticised as restrictive of civil liberties.

For the first question, the evidence in Section 5.1 showed that securitising rhetoric across the post-9/11 period amongst the four major parties did not converge but instead broadly held stable up to 2015 before diverging substantially by 2024. Decomposing that divergence into its constituent dimensions revealed that despite this growing cross-party divergence in the proportion of their manifestos that securitise, the intensity of threat articulation has become a shared baseline across all four parties whilst urgency and justification have become the dimensions that distinguish the governing party from the rest. Separate analysis of the Northern Irish parties at the composite level complicated characterising the broader field by any single perspective though, as they largely converged towards greater intensity as the majors diverged.

For the second question, the analysis in Section 5.2 showed the relationship between party-level securitising discourse, public issue salience and securitising legislation is not a uniform one but one that instead varies between incumbent and securitisation sub-sector. Across parliaments the rhetoric-legislation relationship inverted, with Conservative incumbent rhetoric falling from 1.62% to 1.17% whilst opposition mean rhetoric rose from 1.47% to 1.81%, which sat alongside legislation enactment that reached an all-time high of eleven Acts under the lowest-ranked incumbent of the study. The rhetoric-salience relationship was similarly inconsistent, with incumbent rhetoric highs (Labour 2005, Conservative 2015) coinciding with elevated salience in at least one sector whilst the 2019 Conservative manifesto was at its study-window rhetoric low despite the Political sector

reaching its 65% peak. The salience-to-legislation relationship was more stable but still only partial, with Societal and Economic sector Acts showing clearer co-occurrence with their salience series but the Military sector legislation being independent of its own.

Read together, the two findings combine into a fuller picture. Section 5.1 identified urgency as the dimension carrying the split among the four majors whilst threat converged, meaning composite-level opposition-incumbent asymmetry must itself trace to urgency. The Conservative incumbency's highest legislative throughput being both at their lowest rhetorical position and in the face of rising opposition rhetoric therefore aligns with a structural reading, most clearly anchored in this period, in which rhetoric is the opposition parties' primary channel for staking securitising positions whilst incumbents, with direct legislative access, have less cause to escalate it, with urgency expression in particular carrying that opposition channel.

Several of the limitations I noted in Section 5.3 could feasibly be addressed by tweaks to this framework, which would be worth pursuing in future work. The most direct target is the urgency dimension's structural ceiling. Extending my Data-Programming-inspired weak labelling [59] to include pattern-based labelling functions for detecting co-occurrences of modal verbs with temporal markers (like when, for instance, 'must' sits within n tokens of 'immediately') could capture the syntactic urgency constructions that lexicon matching alone could not reach, potentially addressing its persistent underperformance without needing additional gold annotation. Urgency may also benefit from extending the encoder's input to include preceding and/or following sentences, because incorporating wider discourse-level context into the model's input would address the structural limitation of sentence-level processing that disproportionately affects urgency.

Beyond those urgency-specific improvements, the six-election study window that constrained a full time-series inference in Section 5.2 could be addressed by extending the corpus backwards using MARPOR's UK coverage, although doing this would need the legislation timeline to be rebuilt and alternative public opinion data to be sourced (as the Ipsos Issues Index only goes back to 1974), making that a substantially larger undertaking than just expanding the corpus.

Other relevant future-work items would be expanding the gold annotation set beyond its current 1,500 sentences and introducing a second annotator to establish inter-annotator reliability on a held-out subset. Together these would address confidence in the gold labels used to train the model and enable a future application of the codebook as a reusable annotation resource. That foundation would also support evaluation of the model on other political corpora like parliamentary debates and campaign speeches which would establish whether the framework generalises beyond manifestos. Additionally, the cross-national coverage available through MARPOR provides a direct route to replicating this framework on international corpora, which would enable a comparative exploration into whether securitising rhetoric and legislative output relate consistently across different institutional contexts.

Even ahead of those extensions, the empirical findings I present here stand as the first dimensional characterisation of how UK securitising rhetoric has evolved across the post-9/11 period. Underpinning them is my theory-aligned multi-head regression framework for measuring continuous, multi-dimensional securitisation intensity. I have shown that this framework can be adopted to track securitisation as a self-contained rhetorical phenomenon, and also that it extends to examining the relationships between securitising discourse and contextual variables like legislation and public opinion. Together, these capabilities open a direct methodological route to studying how political rhetoric, governance and the public sphere interact across democratic systems, including the potential to identify when rhetorical shifts may signal impending legislative change ahead of enactment.

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APPENDIX A
ANNOTATION CODEBOOK FOR SECURITISATION REGRESSION MODEL LABELS

Purpose and Scope

I designed this codebook to formally establish the annotation framework that should be used to label data for training the model's multi-head architecture. Each sentence should be assigned an independent intensity score on a 0–3 ordinal scale for each of the essential components of a securitising speech act that the Copenhagen School formalised [6], namely threat construction, urgency articulation, and justification of extraordinary power. Manifestos are quite structurally distinct, and securitising rhetoric within them tends to be institutionalised and incremental and also less explicit than in other political communication mediums like speeches. The tiered structure is designed specifically for this by accommodating for both explicitly securitisation and its more subtle indicators that remain distinct from routine policy language. Dimensions should be treated as analytically independent, such that the absence of one signal does not imply absence of others. By accounting for that, annotators will be scoring discursive intensity, not overall political legitimacy, which is what is needed here to keep labels objective.

Annotated Scoring Rubrics

For all of the below dimensions, score assignment should be determined by whatever the highest tier present in the sentence is. No signal scores 0, contextual-tier signals only score 1, secondary-tier signals (with or without contextual) 2 and core-tier signals 3 (with or without secondary or contextual). If the tier is ever ambiguous, the lower score should be picked. Context beyond the sentence boundary can inform interpretation but should not be used to elevate a score in the absence of internal evidence in the sentence.

Threat Construction Annotated Rubric

For this codebook I define threat as a construction within a sentence that frames either an issue, actor or process as posing danger to a valued referent object. Referent objects include (but are not limited to) national security, public safety, public services, economic stability, social cohesion and democratic institutions. A sentence scores beyond zero on this dimension when it escalates beyond just neutral description to a point where it attributes harm, destabilisation or even existential risk to a referent object.

TABLE 4
Threat Construction Scoring Criteria

Score	Tier	Example	Reasoning
0	None	"We will introduce reforms to improve the efficiency of the planning system."	Purely administrative, lacking any evaluative escalation or harm framing.
1	Contextual	"Levels of anti-social behaviour are a concern for many communities."	Identifies a problem in a vulnerability frame but doesn't attribute material harm to a referent object.
2	Secondary	"Uncontrolled migration is placing significant strain on public services and undermining community cohesion."	Secondary-tier harm attribution (strain, undermining) applied to two referent objects; escalates beyond concern without existential framing.
3	Core	"Terrorism poses a direct threat to our national security and our way of life."	An explicit existential framing (our way of life) targeting a core referent object (national security).

Urgency Articulation Annotated Rubric

Urgency is defined here as the rhetorical compression of time. Here, a sentence scores above zero when it frames action as being needed inside a constrained time period, thereby transforming an issue from routine governance into one demanding accelerated or non-deferrable intervention. Context is particularly important for this dimension because forward-looking language describing long-term planning or routine commitments is explicitly excluded.

TABLE 5
Urgency Articulation Scoring Criteria

Score	Tier	Example	Reasoning
0	None	"We will work over the coming years to improve digital infrastructure."	Forward-looking but not time-constrained; no escalation or non-deferral signal.
1	Contextual	"We are committed to tackling serious crime as a key priority."	Commitment framing signals resolve but this imposes no temporal constraint.
2	Secondary	"We must act swiftly to prevent further damage to our local economies."	Secondary-tier escalation ("swiftly", "prevent further damage") implying delay would be harmful; time-sensitive but not emergency vocabulary.
3	Core	"We need to take immediate action to curb the rapid spread of the virus."	Core-tier timeframe collapse (immediate action is required) combined with deterioration framing (rapid spread); emergency vocabulary.

Justification of Extraordinary Power Annotated Rubric

The justification of extraordinary power dimension is designed to capture the rhetorical moves that legitimise exceptional or expanded authority beyond routine governance. A sentence scores above zero when it frames the application of non-standard enforcement, emergency powers or surveillance as a moral obligation and/or necessary response to a serious problem. Routine legislative reform/additions and administrative efficiency measures all score 0 here as these are within established institutional norms and do not invoke any departure from ordinary democratic procedure.

TABLE 6
Justification of Extraordinary Power Scoring Criteria

Score	Tier	Example	Reasoning
0	None	"We will review existing legislation to ensure it remains effective."	Standard democratic review process; no expansion of authority or non-routine framing.
1	Contextual	"We will increase police resources to ensure laws are properly enforced."	An enforcement mechanism inside existing legal norms; capacity increase, not authority expansion.
2	Secondary	"We will introduce new powers allowing authorities to detain individuals suspected of serious criminal activity for extended periods."	This clearly expands state authority beyond existing enforcement norms; secondary-tier duty and legitimacy framing implied by legislative action.
3	Core	"We will introduce emergency powers enabling the government to override existing legal constraints where national security is at risk."	This explicitly invokes emergency authority and suspends the normal legal process.

APPENDIX B
SECURITY LEXICONS

The following tables contain the finalised lexicons I use as labelling functions on the unlabelled manifesto corpus (Section 3.3). I organise each lexicon into signal tiers and assign to those tiers with the theoretical criteria I define in Section 3.2 (full dimension definitions in Appendix A).

Threat Lexicon (n=490)

TABLE 7: Threat Dimension Lexicon

Tier	n	Terms
Core	152	assassin, assassinate, assassinated, assassinating, assassination, assassinations, assassins, assault, atomic, attack, attack on, attacked, attacker, attackers, attacking, attacks, battle, being radicalised, bomb, bombard, bombarded, bombarding, bombardment, bombardments, bombards, bombed, bomber, bombers, bombing, bombing of, bombings, bombs, bombshell, bombshells, brutal invasion, bullet, casualties, casualty, catastrophe, catastrophes, catastrophic, catastrophically, cogs of war, cogs of wars, conflict, conflicts violence, coup, cyberwar, death, deaths, devastating power, drowning, drownings, engine of war, existential threat, existential threats, explosion, explosions, explosive, explosively, explosives, extinction, extinctions, extremism, extremisms, extremist, extremists, fatalities, fatality, fighter, fights, firearms, further attacks, genocide, hybrid warfare, inexcusable violence, infiltrate, infiltrated, infiltrates, infiltrating, infiltration, infiltrator, infiltrators, insurgencies, insurgency, insurgent, insurgents, invaded, invader, invaders, invades, invading, invasion, invasion of, invasions, islamist extremism, killer, killers, killing, killings, kills, killswitch, killzone, landmine, lethal, linked terror, missile, monster, monsters, netwar, nuclear, peril, perils, punishment attacks, securities, serious threat, serious threats, survival, terror movements, terrorism, threat, violence, violent, violent extremism, violently, war, war engine, war engines, war machine, war machines, warfare, warfield, warfighter, warfighting, wargame, wargames, warhead, warheads, warmonger, warmongering, warmongers, warpath, warplane, warplanes, wars, wartime, weaponise, weaponised, weaponize, weaponized, weaponry, weapons
Secondary	232	a weapon, aegis, aggression, airpower, antipersonnel, arm industry, armament, armaments, armies, arming, armory, armour, armoured, armoury, arms, arms industry, army, atrocities, authority, barbarian, barbarians, blockade, blockaded, blockades, blockading, brutal, capitulate, capitulated, capitulating, capitulation, coerce, coerced, coercing, coercion, coercive, combat, combatant, combatants, combated, combating, combats, combatting, conflicts, countercyber, counterfeit, counterfeits, crime, crime gangs, crimes, criminalisation, criminalise, criminalised, criminalization, criminalize, criminalized, criminalizes, criminalizing, criminally, crisis, cybersphere, demise, demises, destabilise, destabilising, destabilization, destabilize, destabilized, destabilizing, destructed, destructible, destruction, destructions, destructive, destructively, destructor, deteriorate, deteriorated, deteriorates, deteriorating, deterioration, dictator, disaster, disease, disintegrate, disintegrated, disintegrates, disintegrating, disintegration, disobedience, disobedient, dominance, dominant, dominantly, dominate, dominates, dominating, domination, dominator, dominators, drugs, emerging threats, enemies, enemy, escalation of, espionage, espionages, evil, existential, faction, fight back, forceful, forcefully, fuel conflicts, fundamentalism, fundamentalist, fundamentalists, gang, grave, hazard, hazardous, hazards, hegemonic, hegemony, hostile, hostiles, illegal, illegal immigrant, illegal immigrants, illegal migrant, illegal migrants, illegality, illegally, illegals, illicit, infiltrations, inhuman, insecure, insecurities, insecurity, international terrorism, interpol, invisible enemies, invisible enemy, lawbreakers, lawless, lawlessness, menace, menaces, militaries, militarisation, militarised, militarism, militarist, militaristic, militarization, militarized, munitions, oppressive regimes, opressive regime, our threat, paramilitaries, paramilitary groups, partisan, prisoners of, proliferating, proliferation, racism, racist, racists, radicalisation, radicalise, radicalised, radicalising, radicalism, radicalization, radicalize, radicalized, radicalizing, radicals, repressive, repressive regime, repressive regimes, rival, rivals, rogue, ruthless, seapower, security priorities, separatism, separatist, separatists, shortage, suicide, superpower, surveillance, terminated, termination, terror, terrorise, terrorised, terrorising, terrorist, terroristic, terrorists, terrorize, terrorized, terrorizes, terrorizing, terrors, threaten, threatened, threatening, threateningly, threatens, threats, toxic legacies, trafficked, trafficker, traffickers, trafficking, traffics, under attack, uprising, vicious, vulnerabilities, vulnerability, vulnerable, vulnerables, wound, wounded, wounding, wounds
Contextual	106	7/7, 9/11, a cancer, abm, afghanistan, alqaeda, arab, at war, at wars, ballistic, biological, blitz, blocked, blocks, chechnya, chemical, cluster, colonial, crimea, crimean, criminal, criminals, daesh, day slavery, division, fighters, fighting, fln, forces, fragile, gaza, guerrilla, guevara, gulf, hamas, hezbollah, hiroshima, hussein, ira, iran, iraq, islamic, islamist, israel, israeli, israelis, israelite, israelites, israels, killed, kurd, kurdish, kurdistan, kurds, lebanon, libya, military, muslims, nagasaki, narcotics, nationalisation, nationalist, nationalistic, nationalists, nato, nazi, new verdun, new verduns, nine eleven, nine-eleven, of helplessness, osce, pakistan, palestine, pearl harbor, rwanda, rwandan, salw, salwar, sarin, sea power, sea powers, seven seven, seven-seven, sexporting, shock, soft generation, somalia, strike, suffering, syria, target, the innocent, the troubles, under attacks, vietnam, virus, viruses, war on, wars on, wave, waves, wmd, world war, world wars, zombie

Urgency Lexicon (n=94)

TABLE 8: Urgency Dimension Lexicon

Tier	n	Terms
Core	37	act now, action now, armageddon, breaking point, cannot delay, collapse, collapsed, collapses, collapsing, crises, from day one, immediate, immediate action, immediate actions, immediately, imminent, imminently, last chance, life threatening, life-threatening, national crisis, now or never, on day one, point of no return, supreme priorities, supreme priority, ticking clock, tipping point, too late, unparalleled, urgency, urgent, urgent priorities, urgent priority, urgently, within hours, without delay
Secondary	40	can't delay, can't wait, cannot afford, cannot wait, critical, decisive action, decisive actions, emergency, end degrading, escalate, escalating, escalation, growing crisis, inevitabilities, inevitability, inevitable, irreversible, mounting, move swiftly, must not delay, mustn't delay, overdue, overrun, paramount, react, reaction, reactions, reacts, requires action, scarce, scarcely, scarcity, spiralling, swift, swiftly move, swiftly moves, threatening crisis, unprecedented, wakeup call, worsening
Contextual	17	any longer, before the election, crisis, degrading corridor, degrading window, demand, ensure, make sure, move quickly, move rapidly, push to, quickly move, quickly moves, rapidly move, rapidly moves, strive for, tackle

Justification Lexicon (n=233)

TABLE 9: Justification of Extraordinary Power Dimension Lexicon

Tier	n	Terms
Core	65	can't wait, cannot wait, counter attack, counter attacks, counter-attack, counter-attacks, counteracts, counterattack, counterattacks, counterinsurgency, counterinsurgent, counterterrorism, countervail, countervailing, curfew, curfews, disarmament, disarmed, disarming, disarms, exceptional means, exceptional measure, exceptional measures, extraordinary means, extraordinary measures, forbid, forbidden, forbidding, forbids, further attack, homeland, hostage, interdiction, liberate, liberated, liberates, liberating, liberation, liberator, liberators, martial law, martial laws, nonproliferation, punitive, resist, resistance, resistances, resisted, resisting, restore order, retaliate, retaliation, revenge, sanctioned, sanctioning, sanctions, siege, sieges, state of emergencies, state of emergency, staunch defense, ticking clock, tipping point, war crimes, without delay
Secondary	89	abate, abatement, abolish, abolition, age limits, age verification, anti terrorism, beyond politics, commander in chief, commander-in-chief, commanders-in-chief, compelling, compels, compromise, containment, controlling, controls, decisive action, decisive actions, decree, decrees, defend, demand, deport, deported, deteriorating, deterred, detterence, detterent, detterents, embargo, enforce, enforcement, expedite, fast track, fight back, humanitarian intervention, interdependence, interdependent, investigation measures, keep safe, lockdown, lockdowns, maintain order, mobilise, mobilises, mobilize, mobilizes, monitor, overdue, overhaul, powers, preempt, preempted, preemption, preemptive, preemptively, prerogative, prerogatives, preserving the, proportionate measures, protect, protection, protections, rescue, security of, solemn duties, solemn duty, sovereign, sovereigns, sovereignty, stabilise, stabilised, stabilising, stop the boats, stronger control, stronger controls, suspension, suspensions, take proportionate, terrorism prevention, threats posed, to peace, to protect, uncooperating, uncooperative, upholding the, will resist, worsening
Contextual	79	anarchy, armistice, border closure, border closures, break free, breaking free, can't accept, ceasefire, close our border, close our borders, close the border, close the borders, concession, conciliation, conciliatory, cooperate, cooperated, cooperates, cooperating, cooperation, crack down, crack downs, crackdown, crackdowns, curb, deter, deterrence, don't accept, détente, force border, forced, halt, halting, intervene, intervention, introduce, lawfully, not accept, oversee, prevent, preventable, preventative, preventing, prevention, preventive, protect frontline, protecting people, protective, protectively, protector, protectorate, protectorates, protectors, protects, remove, sanction, securities, security, securitys, shut our border, shut our borders, shut the border, shut the borders, stop brexit, subject to, surveil, surveillance, surveillances, surveils, tackle, tactical, tactically, tactician, tactics, toughen, toughened, toughening, tougher sentencing, won't accept

APPENDIX C
QUALITATIVE INFERENCE EXAMPLES

Table 10 contains a sample of the sentence-level predictions the final model produces for the temporal analysis. The composite score I refer to is the minimum score across the three dimension predictions, which was chosen because it reflects the requirement that all three securitisation components need to co-occur for a sentence to be considered genuinely securitising.

It is populated with examples from four distinct categories. The first are high-composite score sentences, which I included to confirm that explicitly securitising moves are scored as expected. The second are the sentences near the composite score floor (0.14). These are included to show that when one dimension scores low, it caps the composite regardless of how strongly the other two score, which is what the floor is meant to do. The third are the highest-scoring sentences per dimension, added to demonstrate the independence of the three regression heads. The fourth and final category contains false positives to show cases where the model picked up on markers that lifted it over the threshold even though the underlying rhetorical move was not strictly be securitising. When selecting these examples, I ensured to pick distinct topics so that no single manifesto commitment dominates the examples. I also include party and year metadata to show where each sentence came from.

TABLE 10: Qualitative inference examples drawn from the full auxiliary model's predictions on the manifesto corpus. Composite scores are the minimum across the three dimension predictions. Abbreviations: SNP=Scottish National Party, DUP=Democratic Unionist Party, UUP=Ulster Unionist Party

Party	Year	Sentence	Threat	Urgency	Justification	Stratum
SNP	2019	We will continue to urge the UK government to immediately halt all military support and arms sales to regimes guilty of violations of human rights and international humanitarian law.	0.864	0.950	0.870	High composite
Green Party	2024	Elected Greens will push for the UK to sign the UN Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons, and following this to begin immediately the process of dismantling our nuclear weapons, cancelling the Trident programme.	0.672	0.915	0.808	High composite
DUP	2005	It is essential that emergency powers granted to the security forces remain in place until the terrorist threat is completely eradicated.	0.460	0.653	0.710	High composite
Labour Party	2005	It is right that we do everything in our power to disrupt terrorist networks, and to challenge the conditions that help terrorism to breed.	0.895	0.615	0.582	High composite
Liberal Democrats	2010	We will hold an immediate Strategic Security and Defence Review to ensure that Britain deploys its resources to face the most serious threats to its citizens' security and well-being, including non-military challenges such as climate change.	0.467	0.887	0.687	High composite
Conservative Party	2010	Terrorism remains a major threat to our country and some of the biggest threats to our security do not come from abroad, they are home grown.	0.938	0.141	0.314	Floor
Sinn Féin	2005	The continuing political raids and political policing, the partisan policing of loyalist marches and the lack of action on sectarian attacks and drug dealing must end.	0.928	0.311	0.140	Floor
SNP	2017	SNP MPs will continue to press the UK government to immediately protect their right to live and work in Scotland and the UK.	0.142	0.833	0.472	Floor
Labour Party	2024	War has returned to Europe for the first time in a generation, there is devastating violence in the Middle East, rapid technological change and the climate crisis are fuelling geopolitical tensions, and malign actors are seeking to divide us.	0.958	0.189	0.171	Threat exemplar
UUP	2010	We unreservedly reject any notion of equivalence between those who perpetrated wicked and cowardly acts of terrorism and those who lost their lives defending democracy and the rule of law.	0.946	0.307	0.199	Threat exemplar
Labour Party	2024	It is a national crisis, requiring urgent action.	0.203	0.932	0.415	Urgency exemplar
UUP	2019	We need immediate corrective investment to increase the number of acute hospital beds.	0.182	0.911	0.437	Urgency exemplar
Labour Party	2005	Local councils and police will be able to designate Alcohol Disorder Zones to help pay for extra policing around city centre pubs and clubs, with new powers to immediately shut down premises selling alcohol to underage drinkers.	0.282	0.153	0.735	Justification exemplar
UKIP	2015	UKIP will do its utmost to deport foreign criminals and prevent those with criminal records from entering Britain, when we leave the EU.	0.354	0.227	0.709	Justification exemplar

Continued on next page

Table 10 continued from previous page

Party	Year	Sentence	Threat	Urgency	Justification	Stratum
DUP	2010	Our experience in facing down terrorism in Northern Ireland has allowed us to frame the debate nationally as to how the United Kingdom responds to the unprecedented threat we all now face.	0.903	0.232	0.152	False positive
Green Party	2015	International obligations to accept refugees, whether seeking sanctuary from wars, political repression or climate change.	0.939	0.275	0.167	False positive

Regarding the false positives above, in both cases the model has picked up on language that very often appears in sentences with high threat articulation, but in these cases are being used in routine policy articulation. They both also mis-interpret the urgency of their contexts, assigning a moderate but non-negligible score to it when in reality the tone is more neutral.

APPENDIX D
SECURITISING LEGISLATION

The table below lists the 24 Acts used as event markers in the temporal analysis (Section 4.3), classified into five Copenhagen School sectors following the criteria established in Section 3.2.

TABLE 11: Securitising Legislation: Acts, Copenhagen School Sectors, and Rationale

Act	CS Sector	Securitisation rationale
Terrorism Act 2006	Military	Criminalised spreading and encouraging terrorist publications and also extended pre-charge detention to 28 days. Introduced because of the 7/7 bombings.
UK Borders Act 2007	Societal	Established UK's 'Border Agency', mandated automatic deportation for non-UK nationals sentenced for 12+ months and introduced biometric documents for foreign nationals immigrating to the UK.
Banking (Special Provisions) Act 2008	Economic	Passed in three days to enable emergency state seizings of failing banks. It also suspended normal property rights via statutory instrument without prior parliamentary authorisation.
Counter-Terrorism Act 2008	Military	Enabled post-charge questioning of terrorism suspects. Also permitted secret inquests and expanded DNA retention and police notification requirements.
Climate Change Act 2008	Environmental	Had legally binding emissions reduction targets framed around existential climate threat. Also, five-year carbon budgets constrained future democratic choices, exhibiting emergency legislation signs.
Banking Act 2009	Economic	Established a permanent 'Special Resolution Regime' that granted the state authority to transfer bank ownership without court authorisation. Also made property rights overridable by ministerial order.
Terrorism Prevention and Investigation Measures Act 2011	Military	Replaced control orders with terrorism prevention methods that imposed overnight residence requirements and travel restrictions without criminal conviction.
Immigration Act 2014	Societal	Introduced right-to-rent checks on landlords and NHS surcharges on migrants. Additionally, restricted appeal rights for immigration decisions.
Data Retention and Investigatory Powers Act 2014	Military	Fast-tracked through Parliament in only four days. It reinstating bulk data retention after the European Court of Justice invalidated the underlying Directive. Also extended extraterritorial interception warrant powers.
Counter-Terrorism and Security Act 2015	Military	Introduced temporary exclusion orders for British nationals abroad and imposed a Prevent duty on educational and public institutions. Also enhanced passport seizure powers.
Immigration Act 2016	Societal	Criminalised illegal working, thus creating a new offence for people breaching immigration conditions, and expanded immigration officer seizure powers for enforcement of it.
Investigatory Powers Act 2016	Military	Legalised bulk communication interception, equipment interference and 12-month retention of internet connection records.

Act	CS Sector	Securitisation rationale
Counter-Terrorism and Border Security Act 2019	Military	Extended terrorism offences extraterritorially and made viewing terrorist content online illegal. Also introduced hostile state activity powers.
Covert Human Intelligence Sources (Criminal Conduct) Act 2021	Military	Granted statutory authorisation for undercover agents to commit criminal acts without being prosecuted and also without prior judicial oversight.
Economic Crime (Transparency and Enforcement) Act 2022	Economic	Was fast-tracked in two weeks following Russia's invasion of Ukraine to accelerate sanctions implementation. It established a 'Register of Overseas Entities' and strengthened Unexplained Wealth Orders.
Police Crime Sentencing and Courts Act 2022	Political	Gave police powers to impose conditions on one-person protests. Additionally, it created offences for causing serious annoyance and also extended stop-and-search powers.
Nationality and Borders Act 2022	Societal	Introduced a two-tier asylum system based on mode of arrival, criminalised irregular entry and enabled offshore processing of claims.
Energy Act 2023	Economic	Explicitly framed around energy independence as a national security response to Russian gas dependency. It introduced compulsory acquisition powers for energy infrastructure outside normal procurement.
National Security Act 2023	Military	Repealed the Official Secrets Acts of 1911, 1920 & 1939, introducing new offences (foreign interference and assisting a foreign intelligence service), a Foreign Influence Registration Scheme and an expanded prohibited places regime.
Public Order Act 2023	Political	Introduced 'Serious Disruption Prevention' Orders, creating some new offences like locking-on and tunnelling and enabled stop-and-search without suspicion at protests.
Online Safety Act 2023	Political	Imposed a duty of care on online platforms, granting Ofcom powers to require removal of encryption. Also mandated age verification on 18+ websites and enabled website blocking.
Illegal Migration Act 2023	Societal	Imposed a duty to remove all irregular arrivals. Also barred asylum claims from those entering via safe third countries and permitted indefinite detention.
Investigatory Powers (Amendment) Act 2024	Military	Required technology firms to notify government before changing products, relaxed oversight thresholds for surveillance warrants and also broadened bulk dataset access.
Safety of Rwanda (Asylum and Immigration) Act 2024	Societal	Mandated treating Rwanda as a safe country by statute, which directly overrode a Supreme Court judgment and disapplied Human Rights Act provisions on refoulement.

Note: I considered but ultimately excluded two Acts. The first was the Coronavirus Act of 2020. Although it encroached on peacetime civil liberties, it falls under "Health securitisation", which was an extension of the Copenhagen School's original framework [99] and not examined in this study. The second was the Prevention of Terrorism Act 2005, which, whilst it was a textbook securitising law, it received Royal Assent on 11th March 2005 prior to the 5th May general election so is therefore attributable to the proceeding parliamentary term which is outside my study window.